Party, it began manoeuvring toward a strategic partnership with the Islamic Republic. In 2001, months *before* the 9–11 attacks on the United States, Vajpayee visited Tehran to jointly declare with Iran's leaders a "strategic partnership" between the two countries. Two years later, Iranian President Mohammad Khatami reciprocated Vajpayee's visit by serving as India's honoured guest during its Republic Day parade. Khatami's 2003 visit to India came in the midst of the US build-up for the regime change invasion of Iraq and represented India's support for Iran in its isolated international position at that juncture. The common Iranian–Indian interests that underpinned this initial effort at Indo–Iranian partnership had nothing to do with China, which was still a minor actor in the Middle East. The 2003 Indo–Iranian strategic partnership had to do, rather, with dealing with the Taliban terrorist cancer in Afghanistan and opening of a post-Soviet North–South Corridor together with Russia that would move Caspian Sea oil through Iran to seaports for shipment to India. Development of a new port at Chabahar and roads and, eventually, rail lines north from Chabahar were important components of the North–South Corridor, still very much in the conceptual stage at that time.

New Delhi's push for partnership with Tehran soon came into conflict with India's push for a new strategic partnership with the United States. In 1999–2000, following India's nuclear tests and the crisis in US–India relations that followed those tests, India and the United States undertook a genuine strategic dialogue, really for the first time ever, via the Jaswant Singh–Strobe Talbot talks. Through this critical dialogue, both sides gradually recast their views of the other and reached a new understanding of the extent to which the interests of the two countries converged, not least vis-à-vis China. The revelations of 2003 regarding Iran's clandestine nuclear programmes led to a decade of escalating US-sponsored sanctions against Iran. This confronted New Delhi with a choice: strategic partnership with Iran or with the